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When agents lose their principals

Fixed income liquidity revisited

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See Appendix A-1 for Analyst Certification, Important Disclosures and non-US research analyst disclosures

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Assessing fixed-income liquidity

Regulation and structural change

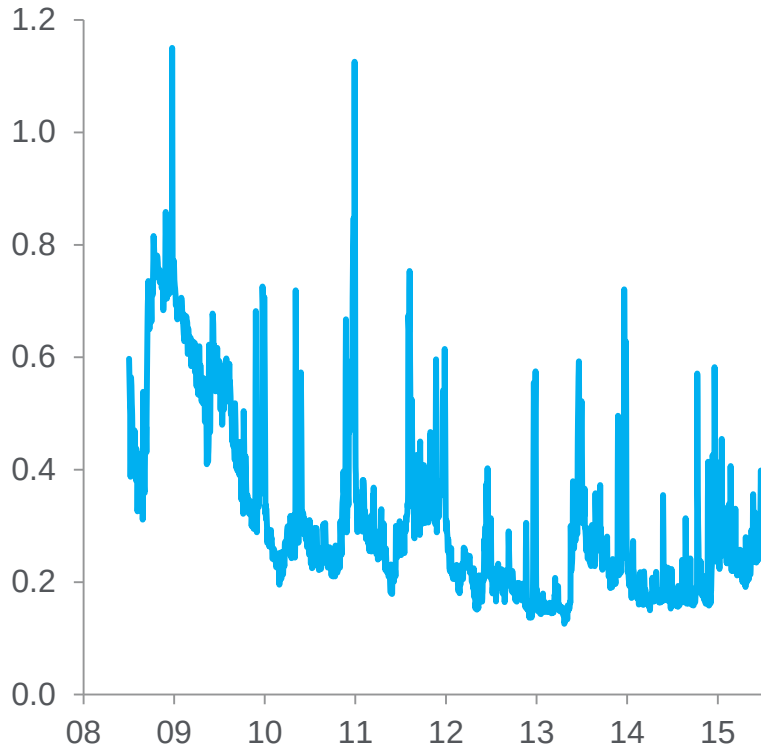
Liquidity in financial shocks

Best practices and innovation

On some metrics, liquidity has seldom been better

UST trading costs lower, if spiky

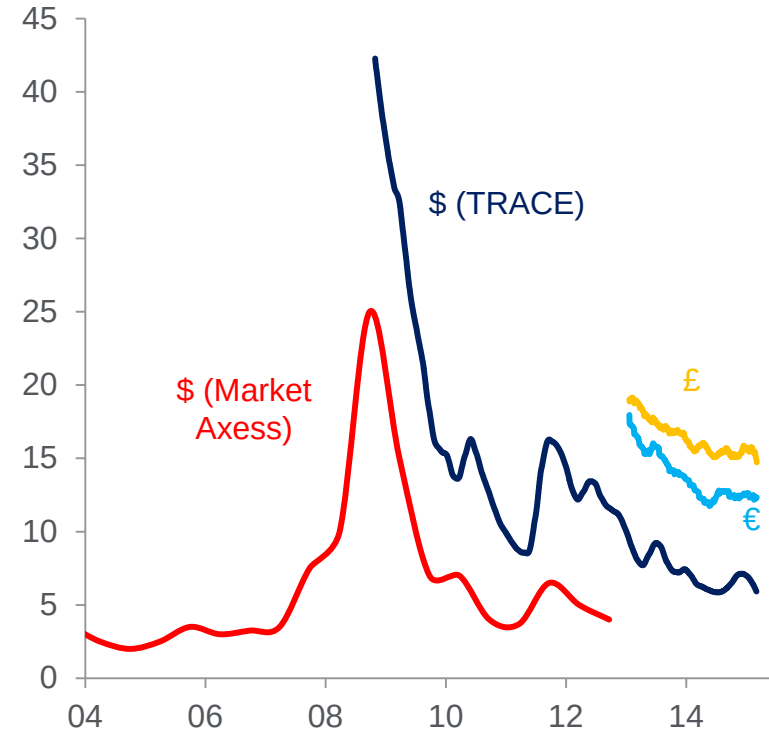
Cost to trade 5k UST contracts, bp of yield



Source: Bloomberg.

Credit bid-offer at post-crisis lows

bp of spread



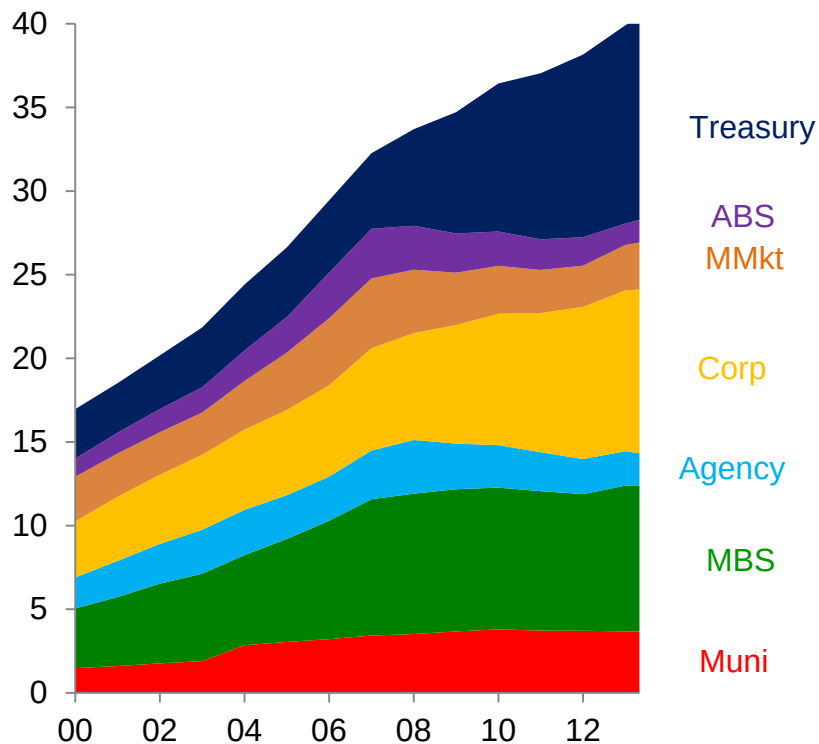
Source: Market Axxess BASI, Citi Research.

Much of the time, the cost of trading is low

But markets are turning over less often

A doubling in UST outstandings...

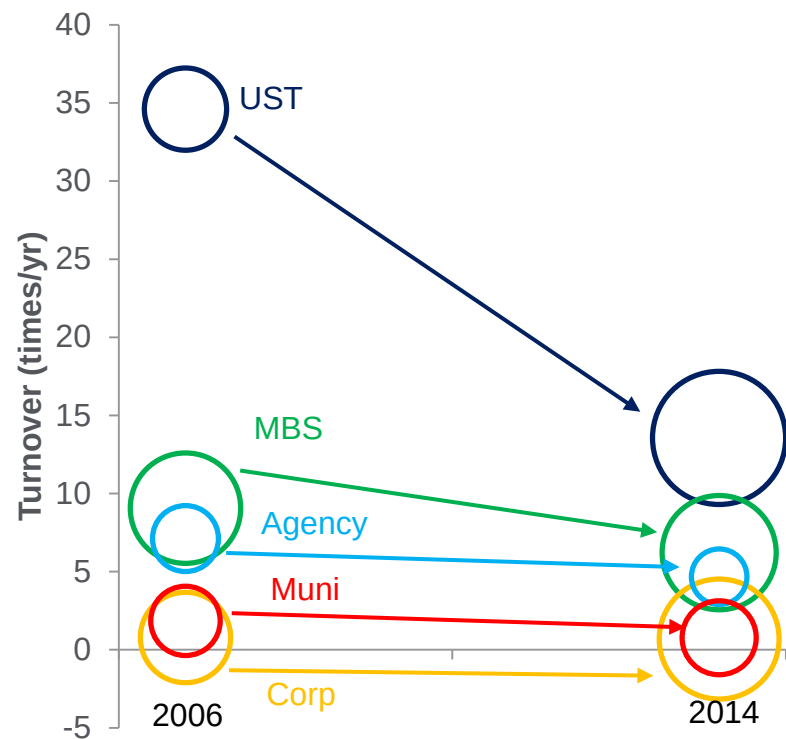
US fixed income outstandings, \$tn



Source: SIFMA.

...only partly explains the drop in turnover

Turnover* and outstandings (size), 2006-2014, ex Fed holdings



Source: SIFMA, NY Fed primary dealer statistics.

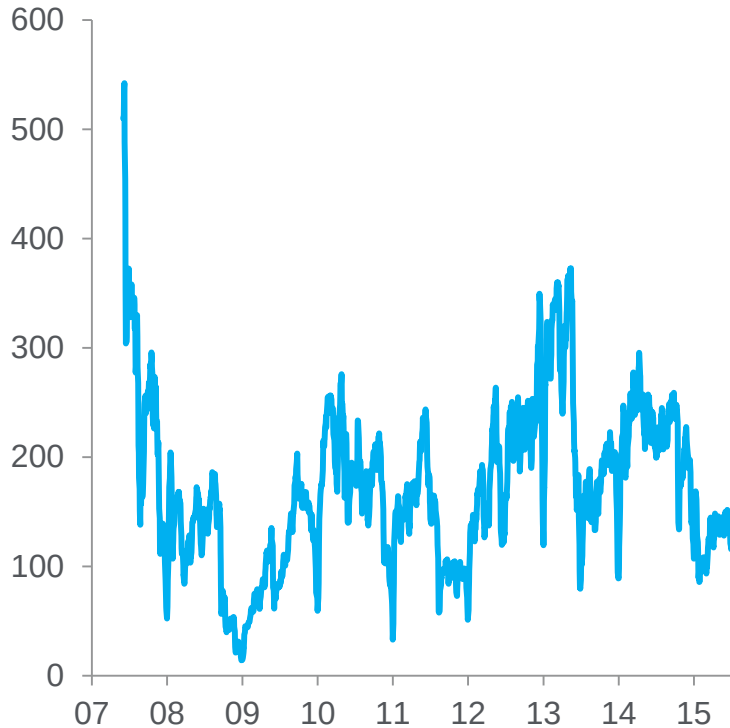
*Omits HFT and other trades not through primary dealers: real decline may be smaller, esp for USTs. However, turnover on Bunds/gilts/JGBs also shows a sharp decline.

The more liquid the market, the more trading has suffered

Depth has fallen

Reduced depth even in on-the-run USTs

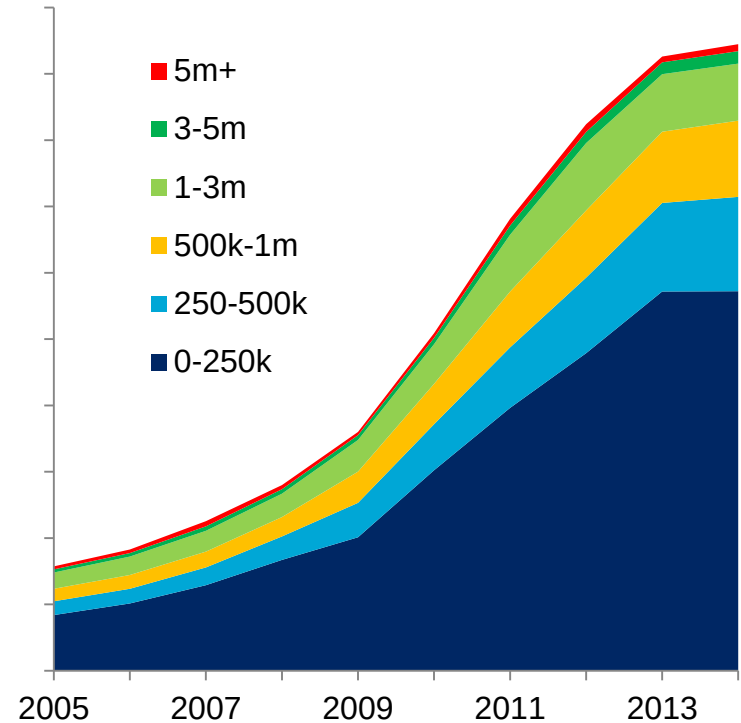
5-day average size of tightest three bids and offers each day, on-the-run 10y UST, \$m



Source: JPMorgan, Bloomberg.

E-trading is mostly in odd-lots

Market Axess US credit inquiry for a large US dealer by size, scale removed



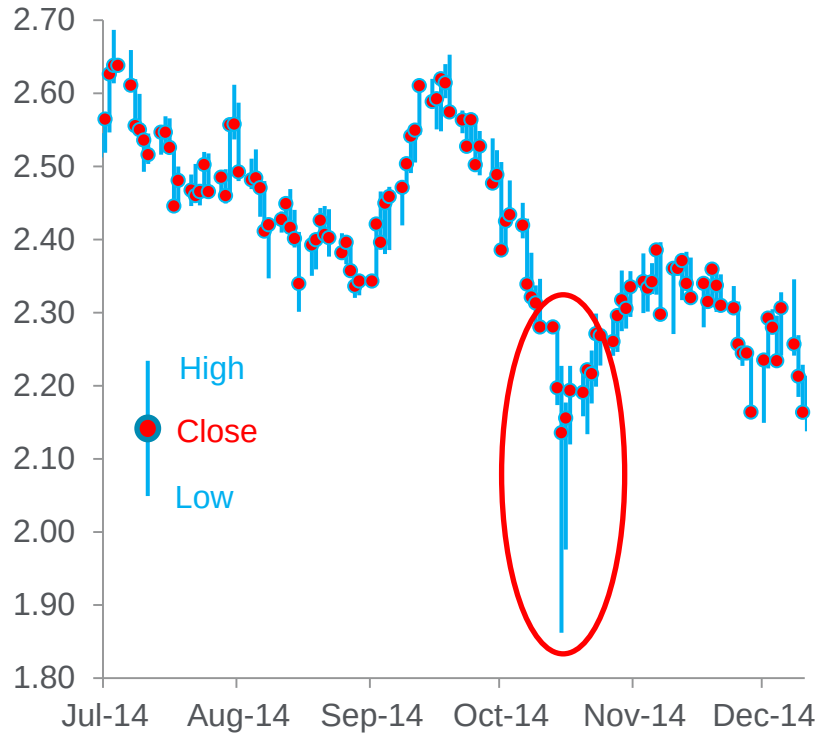
Source: Citi Research.

It is harder to execute large trades

Above all, an increased tendency for liquidity to disappear

A 37bp intraday move in Treasuries

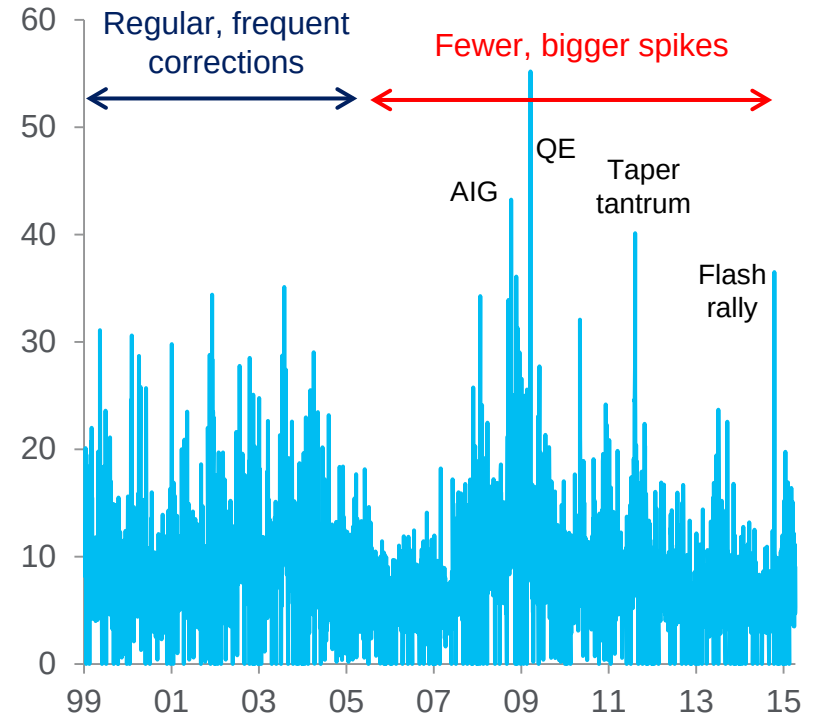
10y UST yield and intraday range, %



Source: Bloomberg.

Previous spikes had obvious causes

Intraday trading range in 10y US Treasuries, bp



Source: Bloomberg.

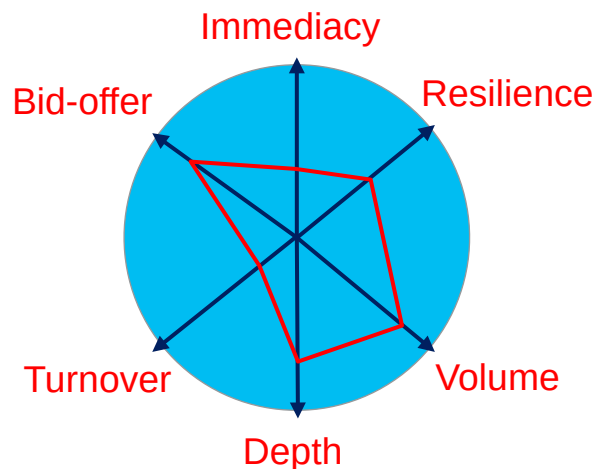
Unexpected bouts of volatility with little obvious explanation

What do we mean by liquidity?

Easily defined

“The ability to transact quickly without exerting a material effect on prices.”

But think less in terms of metrics



And more in terms of preconditions

“Liquidity is optimally achieved when **myriad** buyers and sellers are ready and willing to trade.”

“...enhanced by market-makers and speculators alike...”

“Liquidity exists when investors are **confident** in their ability to transact and where risks are quantifiable.”

Source: “Market Liquidity: Definitions and Implications”, Fed Governor Kevin Warsh, March 2007.

See also Borio, C., *Market liquidity and stress: selected issues and policy implications*, BIS (2000).

Liquidity is created when heterogeneous participants can trade together with confidence

Why fixed income and equities are different

Many more bonds than stocks

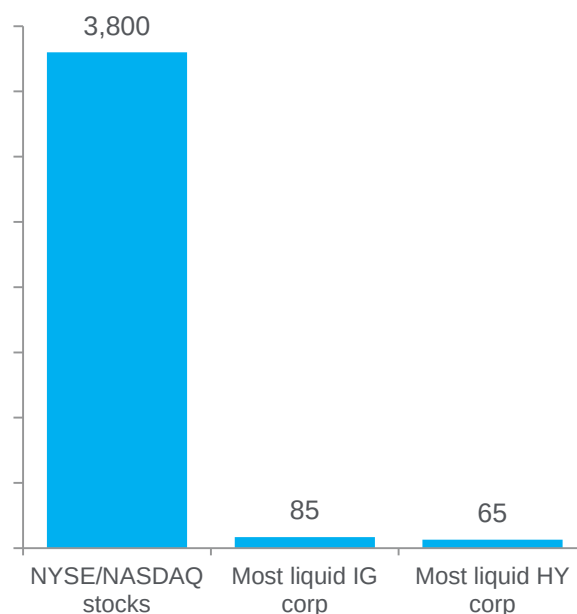
Securities in major equity indices

			Unique securities	Mkt cap (\$tn)
US	S&P 500	Equities	500	19.4
		Bonds	11561	3.3
	Russell 1000	Equities	1000	22.5
		Bonds	12800	3.7
EU	Deutsche Börse	Equities	30	1.1
		Bonds	1174	0.3
	Euro Stoxx 50	Equities	50	2.8
		Bonds	4554	1.1

Source: Bloomberg, May 2015.

Bonds trade less often...

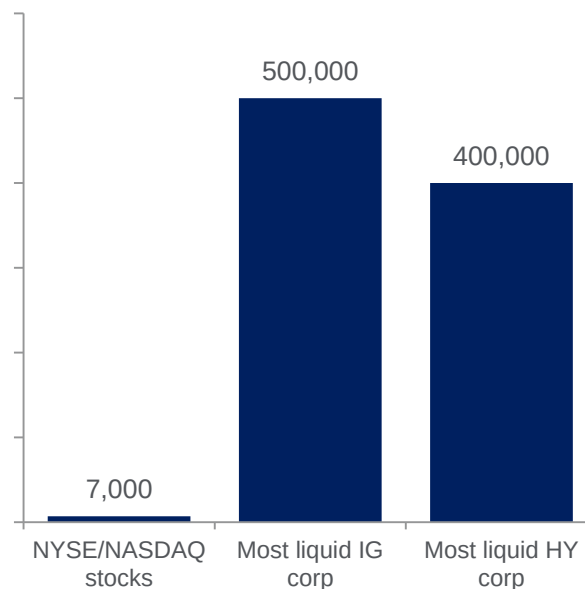
Average # trades per day



Source: McKinsey, NASDAQ OMX Group, NYSE Euronext, FINRA TRACE. Uses top 50 bond issues by trading frequency and value traded in 2012.

...but in much larger sizes

Average trade size, \$



Source: McKinsey, NASDAQ OMX Group, NYSE Euronext, FINRA TRACE. Uses top 50 bond issues by trading frequency and value traded in 2012.

In fixed income, few trades are spread out across many bonds

Principal- versus agency-driven markets (1)

Principal

- Typically non-standardized products
- Larger average ticket sizes; less retail involvement due to instrument features
- No easy borrow, particularly on small size
- Little or no algorithmic market-making
- Sustained two-way flow unlikely without market-makers to commit discretionary capital
- Liquidity takers less willing/able to manage their own execution risk; rely on discretionary capital to warehouse or move risk
- Counterparty identity more important due to lack of active daily trading in most instruments
- Little, if any, firm liquidity; quote-driven trading

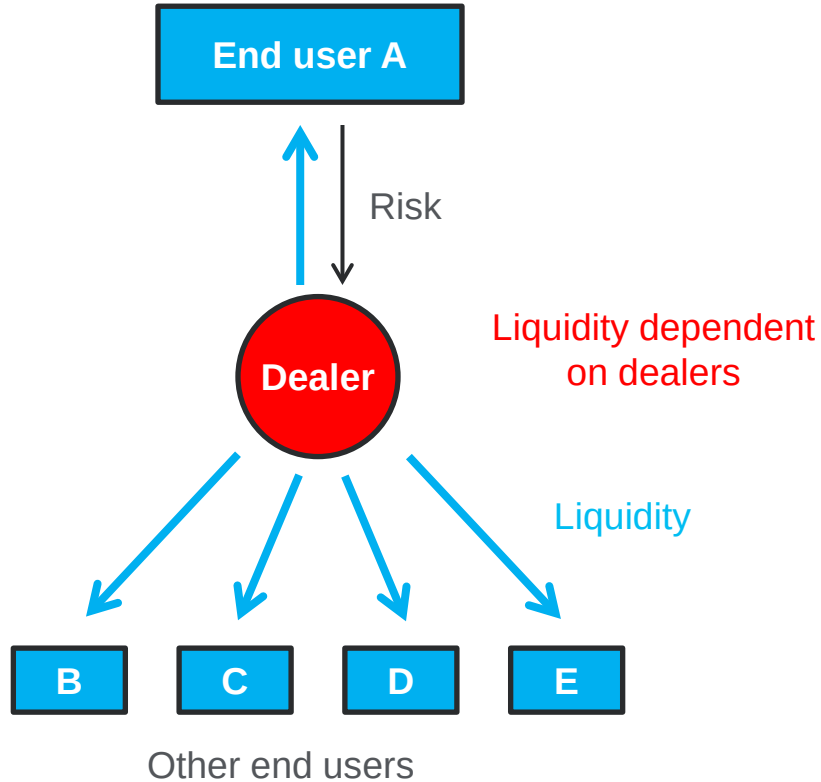
Agency

- Typically standardized products
- Smaller average ticket sizes; strong retail involvement due to simplicity of instruments
- Easy borrow facilitates two-way flow
- Algorithms promote ticket proliferation
- Sustained two-way flow likely without market-makers to commit discretionary capital
- Liquidity takers more willing/able to manage their own execution risk by breaking trades into smaller lots in firm orders
- Counterparty identity less important due to depth of liquidity
- Firm, disparate liquidity on same instrument across multiple venues

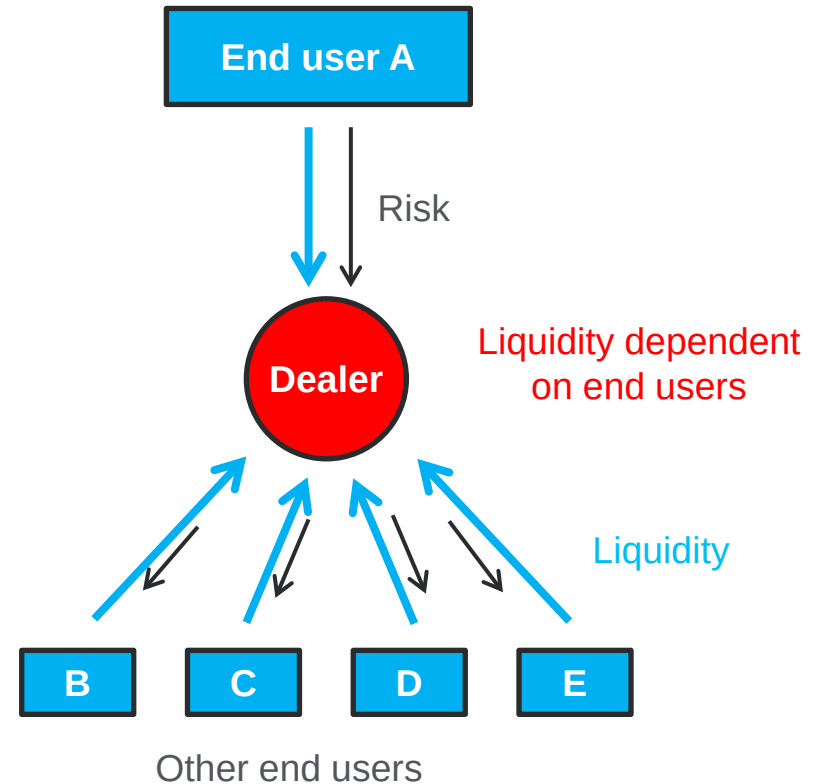
This is why fixed income has traditionally relied on a warehouser

Principal- vs agency-driven markets (2)

Principal



Agency



Source: PIMCO, Citi Research.

Dealer constraints mean FI now becoming less principal- and slightly more agent-driven

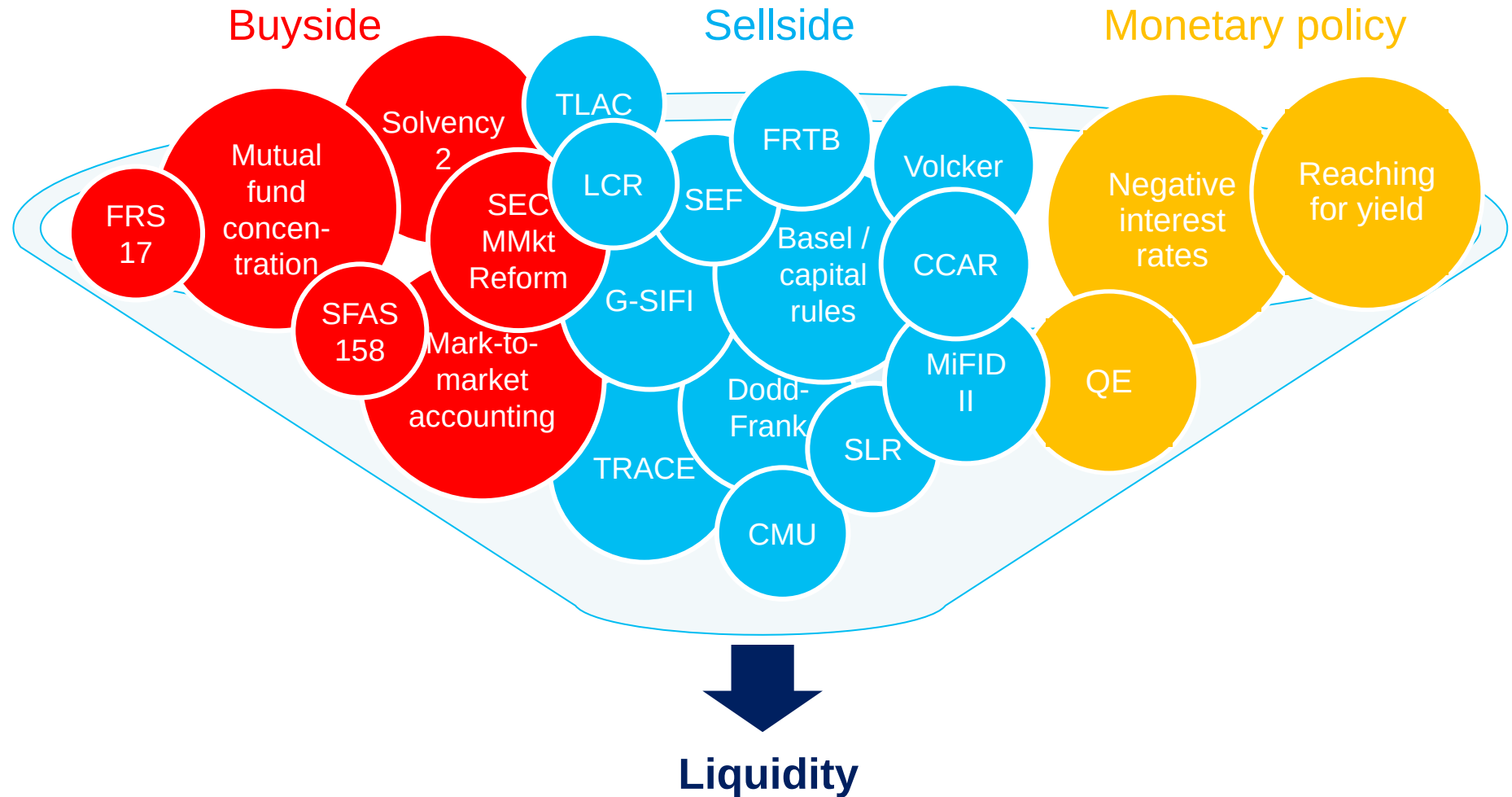
Assessing fixed-income liquidity

Regulation and structural change

Liquidity in financial shocks

Best practices and innovation

Cumulative impact of regulation and policy is difficult to isolate

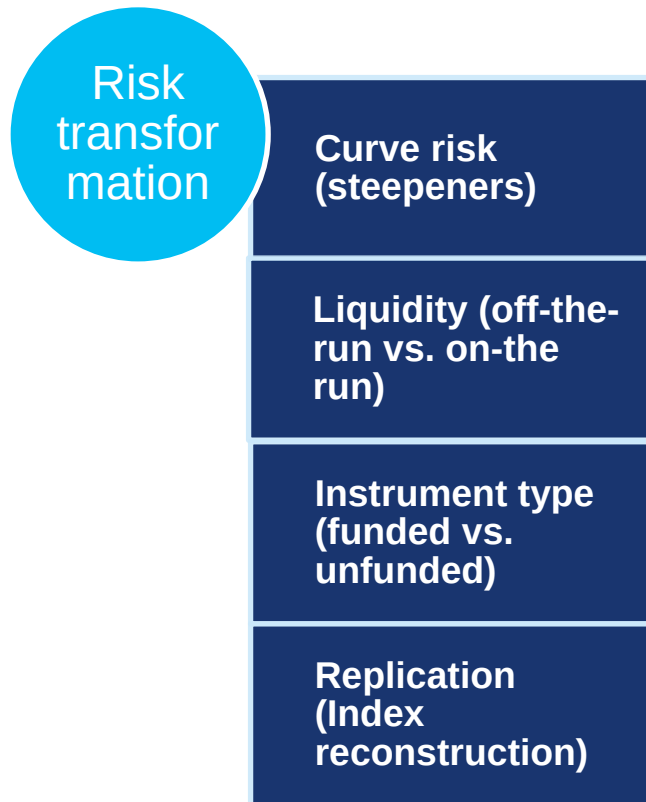


But the combined effect is reduced buffers
and a loss of heterogeneity

Capital rules and the impact on market-making

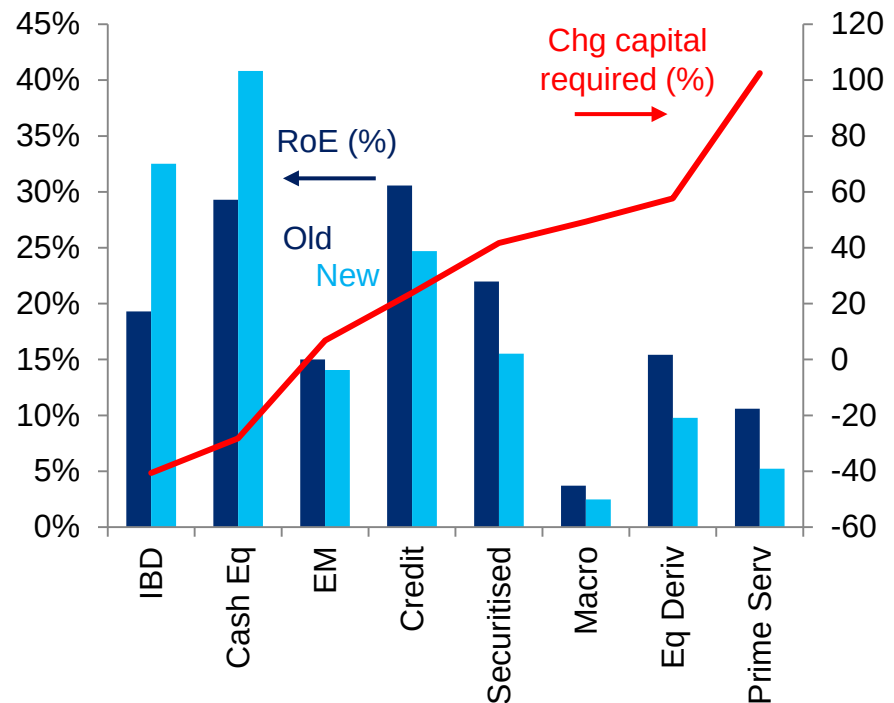
The role of market-maker

Absorbs supply and demand imbalances by transforming risk



Capital costs have risen

Bank* RoE and change in capital estimates under old and new leverage ratio constraints, by business, %



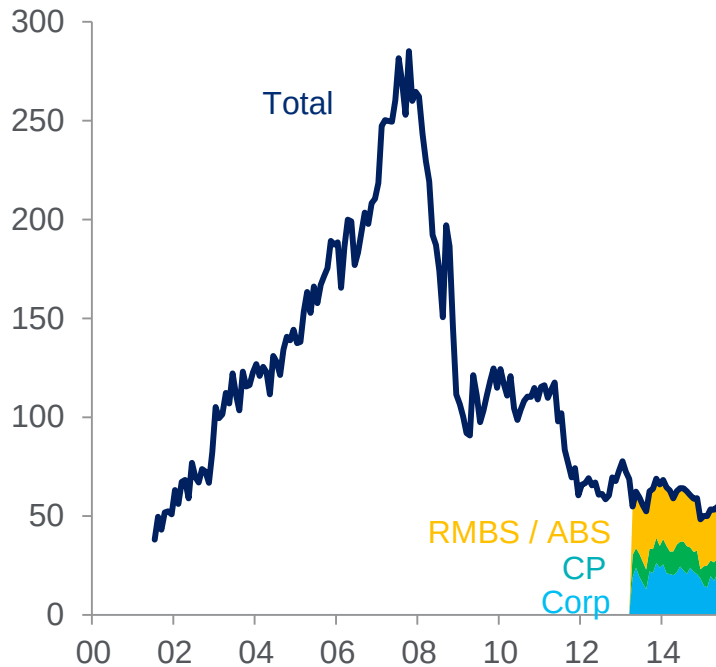
Source: Citi Research. *Numbers derived from one particular bank but are likely to be representative.

Market-making has become more expensive in the many cases where trading requires risk transformation

Street balance sheet has shrunk significantly

Credit* inventory down by 80%

Street holdings of credit*, \$bn

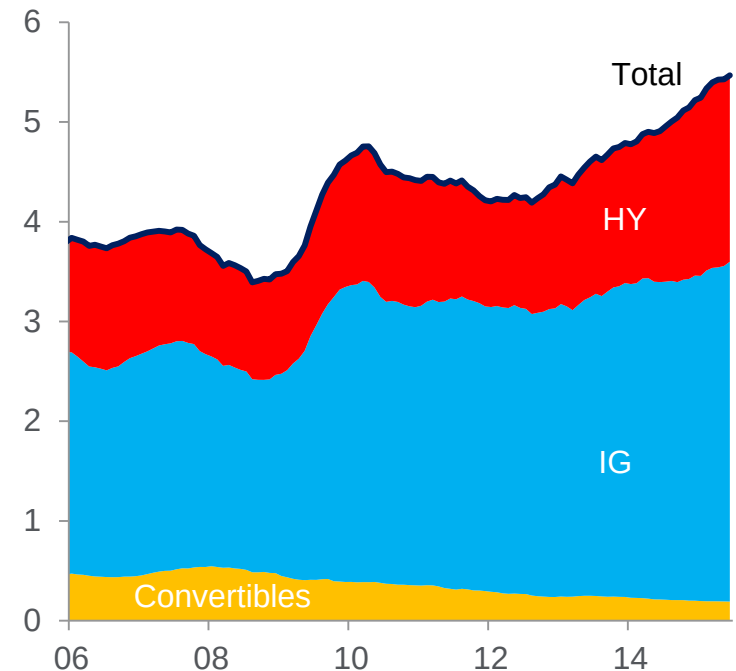


Source: Federal Reserve, TRACE.

*Inventory numbers also include RMBS/ABS, which were likely much larger in 06-07.

Yet traded volumes have risen

Trading in US cash credit, rolling 12m, \$tn



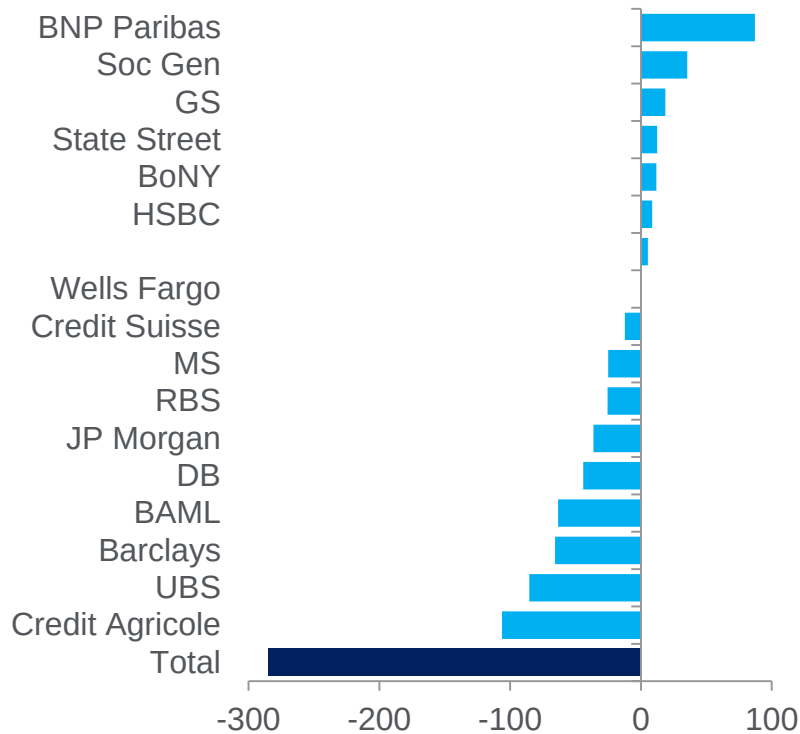
Source: TRACE.

A smaller buffer, but also one less procyclical seller
in a downturn

Less leverage means lower repo

Dealer balance sheet contraction...

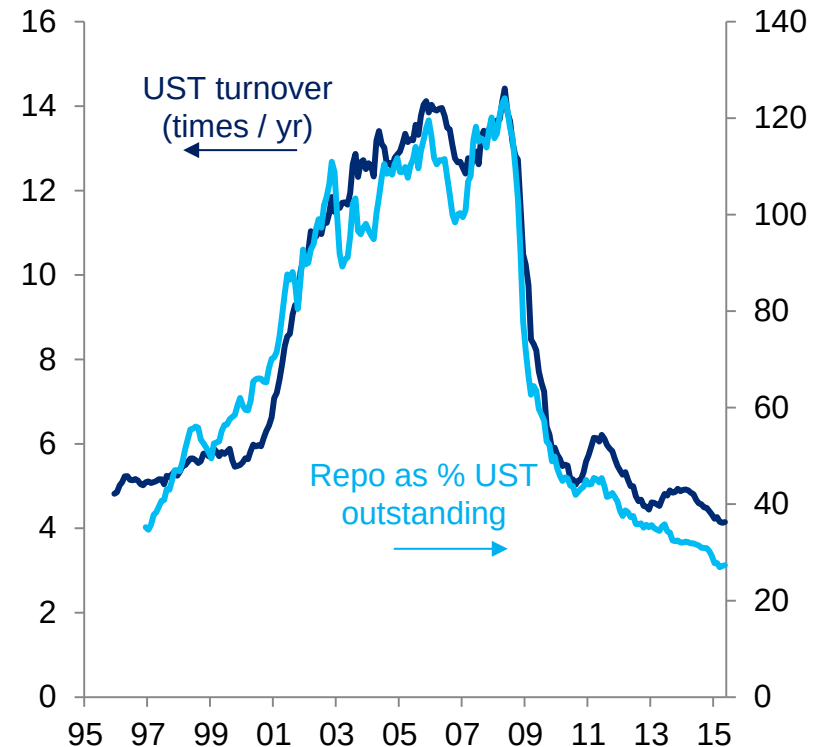
Change in repo book size, 3Q14 vs 4Q12



Source: Company accounts.

...directly impacts traded volumes

UST turnover and dealer reverse repo, vs outstanding



Source: NY Fed.

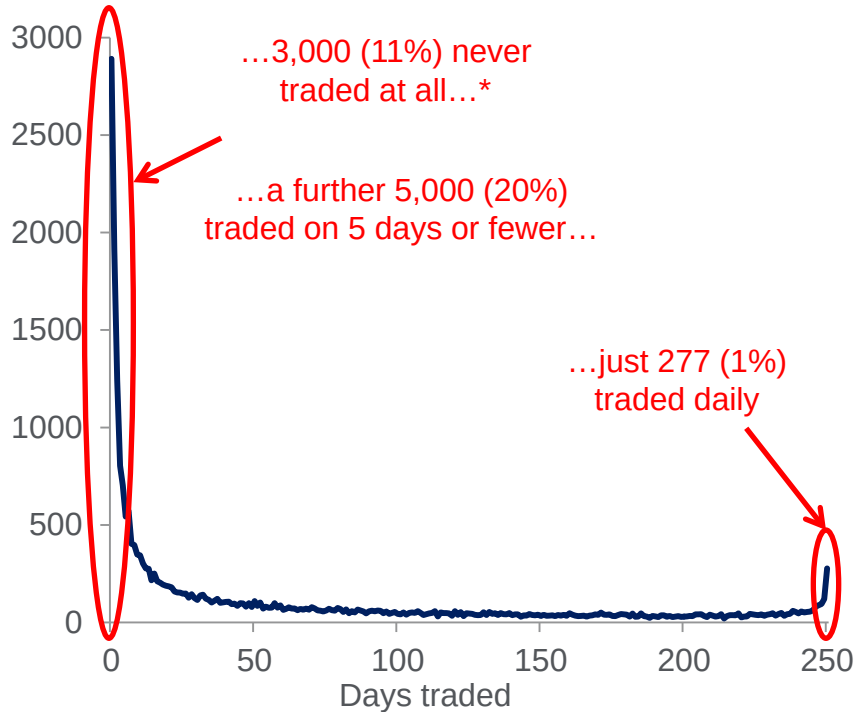
Reduced relative value trading,
especially in low-risk markets

Greater transparency does not always equal greater liquidity

The liquid core is very, very small...

Trading days for US corporate bonds, FY 14

Of 26,000 publicly registered bonds outstanding last year...

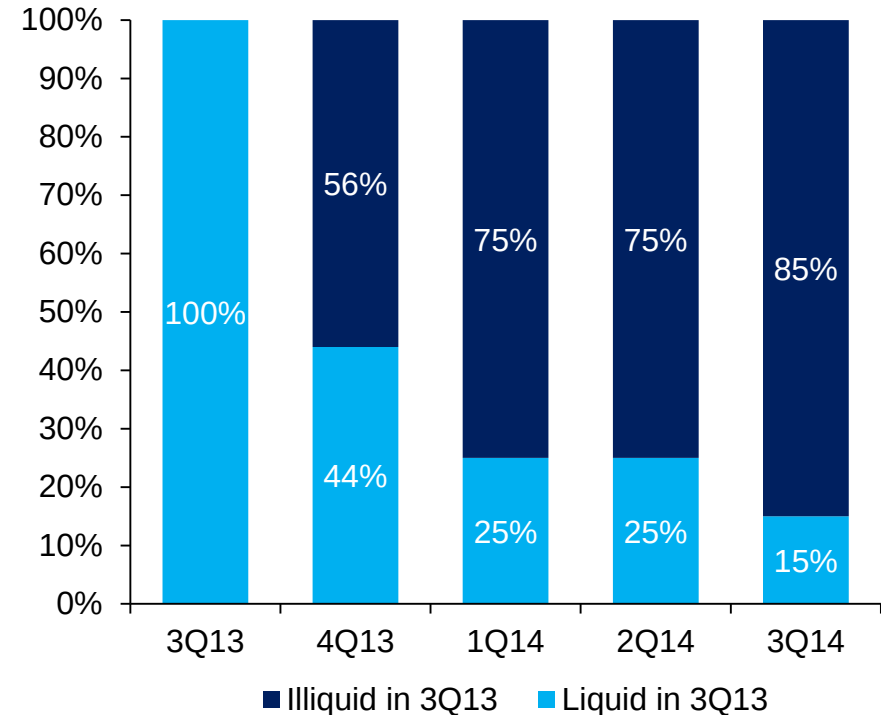


Source: Citi Research, MarketAxess, Bloomberg, TRACE.

*This is just the number of publicly registered bonds which didn't trade. The total number – including private placements and the like – is likely far higher.

...and it migrates through time

Proportion of bonds deemed liquid* in 3Q13 also liquid* in subsequent quarters, € corporates



*Uses ESMA Scenario 6 definition of liquidity: >2,400 trades per year, average daily volume of at least €1m, plus requirements on the number of days the bond traded and number of participants in the market.

Source: MarketAxess Research, Trax.

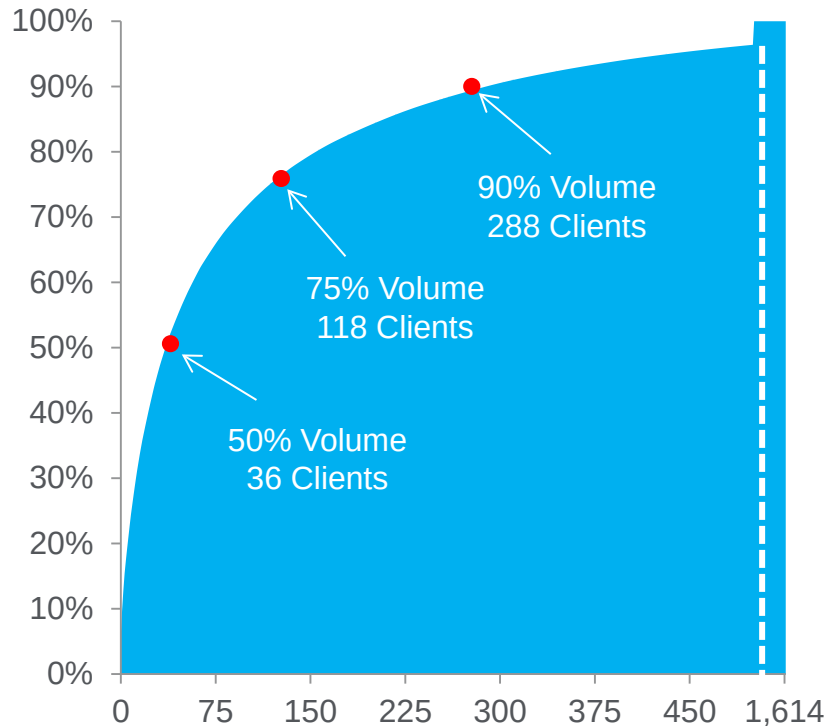
Helpful when properly calibrated, but one size does not fit all

Concentration exacerbates the issue

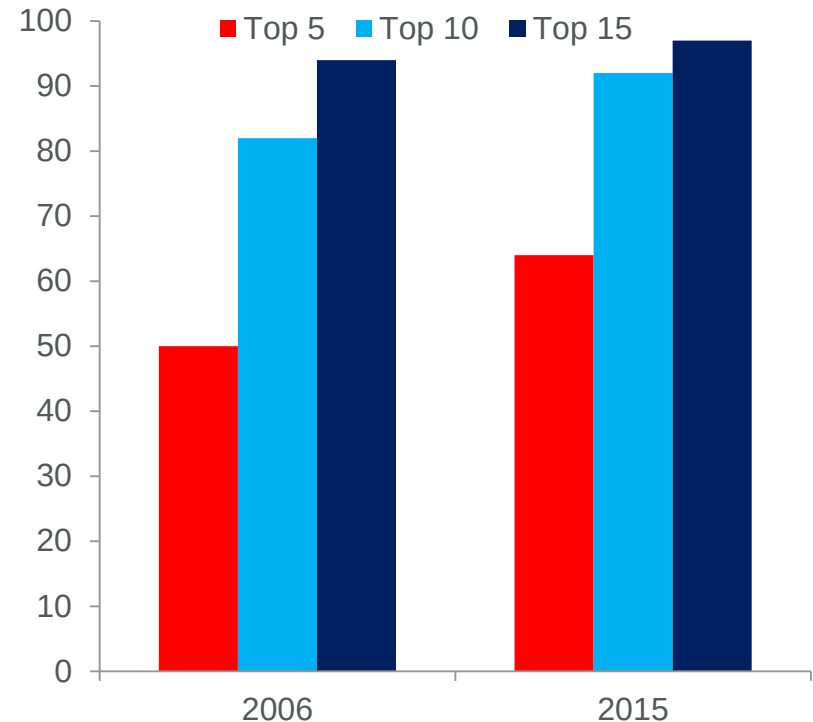
Half the volume from just a few investors... ...who themselves are using fewer dealers

% total US IG volume of a large dealer, FY 2014

Proportion of investor trading by number of dealers, US IG, %



Source: Dealer trade data.



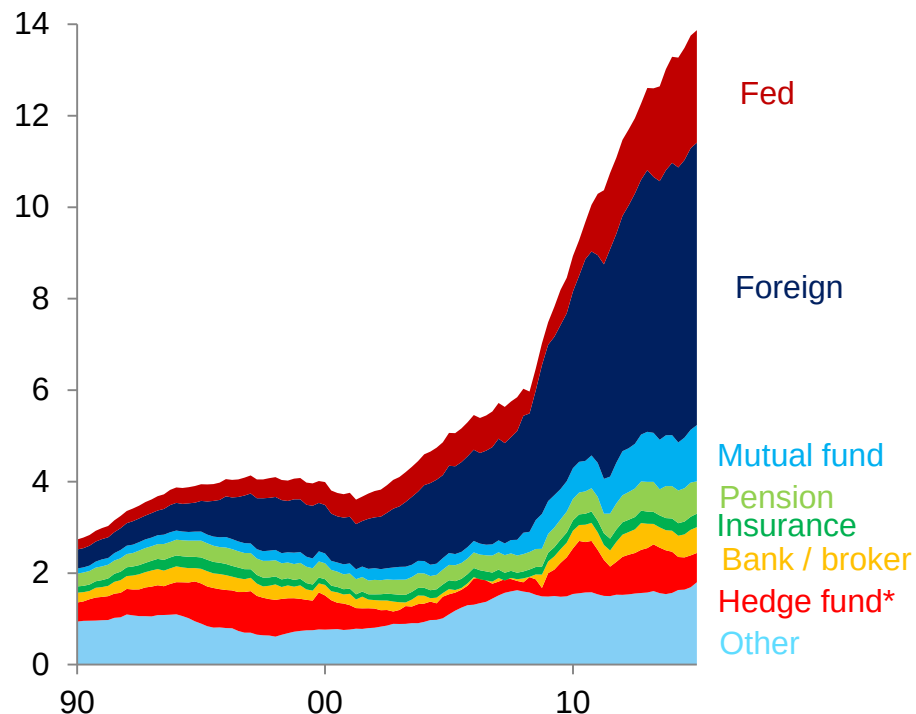
Source: NAM Greenwich Associates Survey.

Illiquidity more likely when activity dominated by a few participants with similar strategies

As do shifts in market structure

Who owns US Treasuries?

Outstandings by owner, \$tn

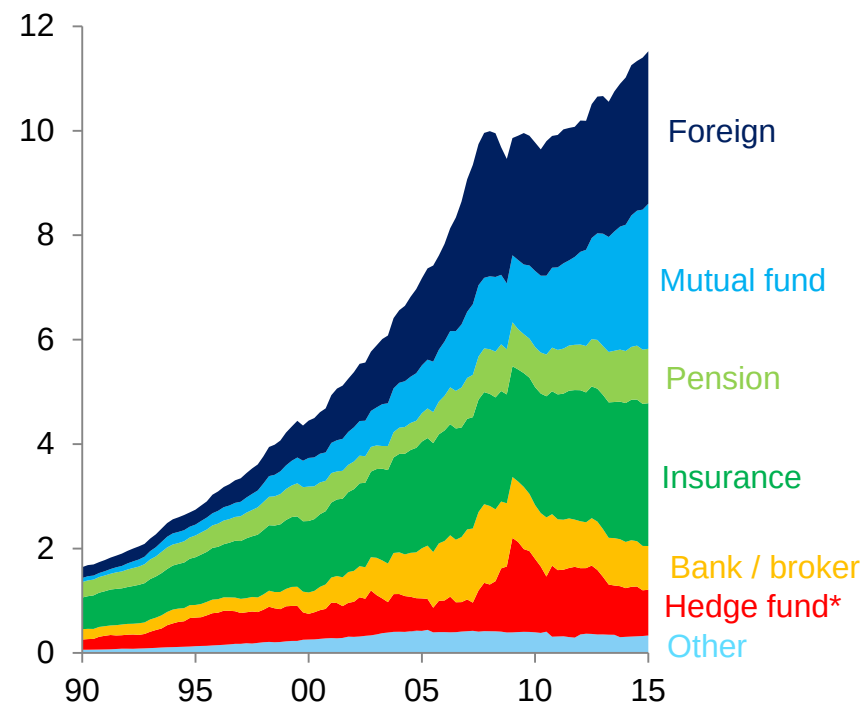


Source: Federal Reserve Flow of Funds, Haver Analytics.

*Although described as "household" in flow of funds, series likely dominated by hedge funds.

Who owns US corporates?

Outstandings by owner, \$tn



Source: Federal Reserve Flow of Funds, Haver Analytics.

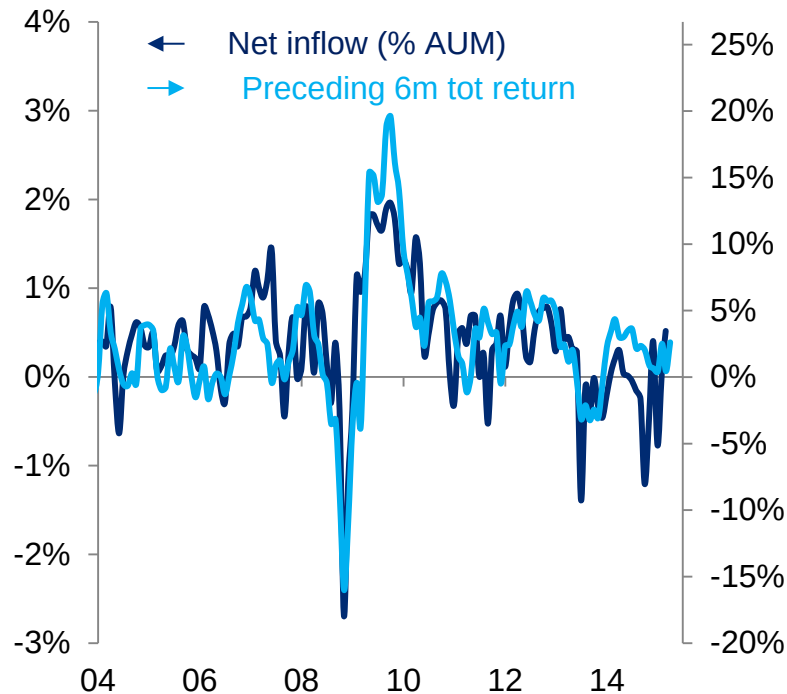
*Although described as "household" in flow of funds, series likely dominated by hedge funds.

Ownership, and especially net buying,
has become much less heterogeneous

Especially when so much buying is procyclical

Mutual fund investors chase returns

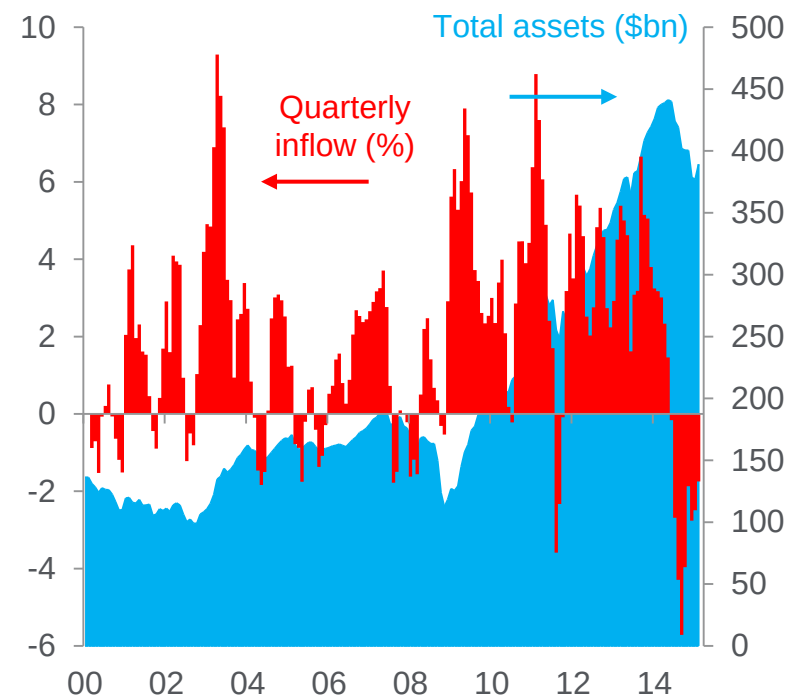
US IG+HY fund inflows vs prior 6m returns, % AUM



Source: ICI, Citi Research.

Higher risk of outflows

US HY fund inflows vs AUM, %



Source: ICI.

More procyclicality,
and more concentration on immediacy

Investors need more conviction to trade

The Cost of Business

Citi US Broad Investment Grade Corporate Index
2005 vs. 2015

	Then	Now
Transaction Cost Scenario	7/21/2005	7/21/2015
Citi USBIG Corporates Index YTM	5.19%	3.40%
Bid-Ask	2-3 bps	5-10 bps
Assume: Midpoint of Bid-Ask	2.5 bps	7.5 bps
Duration	5.9	7.0
Bid-Ask Cost, adjusted for duration, round trip	22 bps	79 bps
Transaction Cost as % of Par	0.22%	0.79%

USBIG Corporates Index Snapshot	7/21/2005	7/21/2015
Eff Duration, USBIG, Corp.	5.9	7.0
Spread to Treasury, USBIG, Corp.	+100 bps	+143 bps
# of Issues, USBIG, Corp.	2,671	5,619
Yield to Maturity, USBIG, Corp.	5.19%	3.40%
Market Value, USBIG, Corp. (\$ bn)	\$1,680	\$4,394
Average Life, USBIG, Corp. (years)	9.3	10.5

Source: Yield Book.

Note: This exercise assumes a switch into a similar bond (price, yield, maturity) assuming selling at mid-market and buying new security at offer side. Costs could of course be reduced by buying in primary – which may be one reason activity has migrated in that direction.

Suppose You Had \$10 Million....

Expected Transaction Costs for Switch Trade, 1 Year Horizon
Holding Spreads & Yields Constant (No Roll-Down)

	Then	Now
Expected Transaction Costs	7/21/2005	7/21/2015
Yield Return, Gross	\$519,053	\$339,824
Bid-Ask Cost, adjusted for duration, round trip	\$21,989	\$78,704
Transaction Cost as % of Yield	4.24%	23.16%

Consider the Break-Even Horizon...

Using Yields & Transaction Costs in 2005 & 2015
Holding Spreads & Yields Constant (No Roll Down)

Then | 2005 break-even period = 15 days

Transaction Cost = 0.22% of par; Market Yield = 5.19%

Now | 2015 break-even period = 85 days

Transaction Cost = 0.79% of par; Market Yield = 3.40%

Higher transaction costs, and lower yields and volatility:
a self-reinforcing disincentive to trade

Assessing fixed-income liquidity

Regulation and structural change

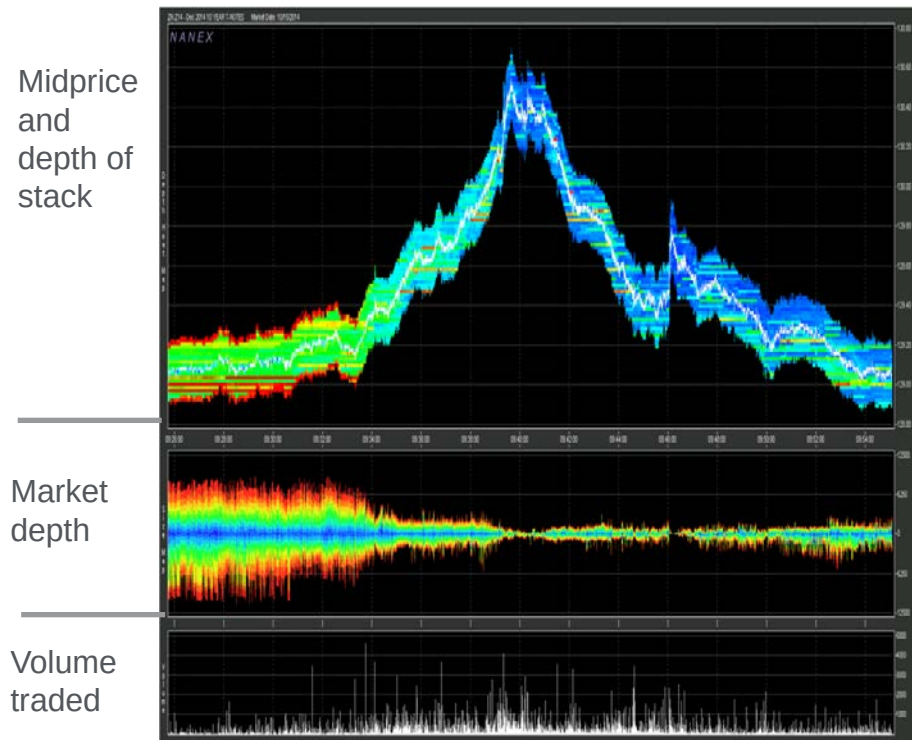
Liquidity in financial shocks

Best practices and innovation

What to make of the flash crash?

Depth just disappeared...

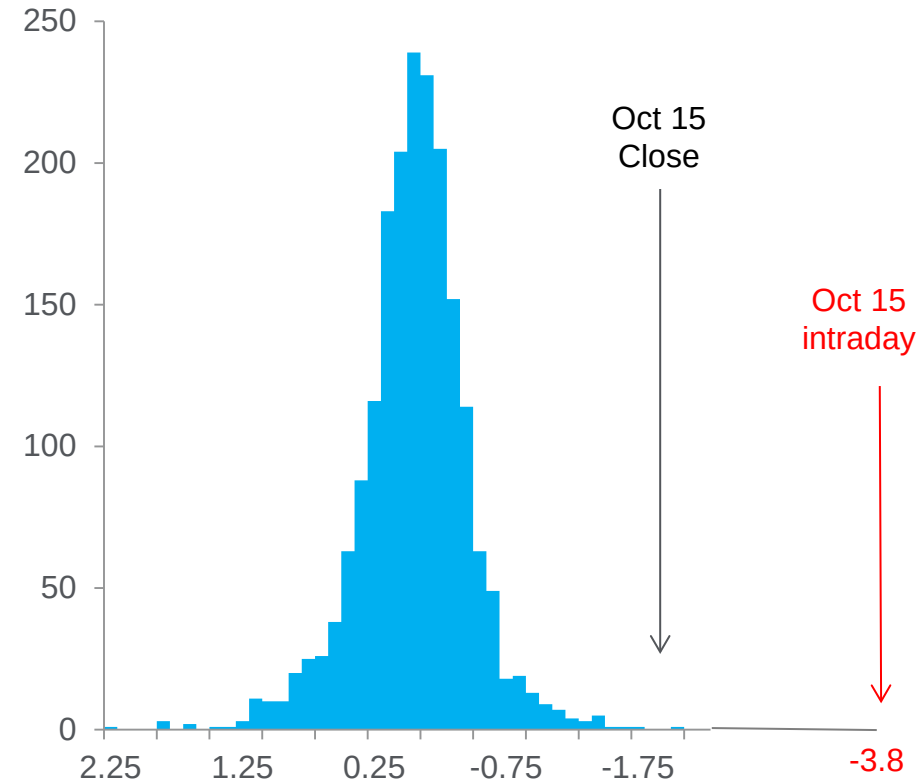
Intraday movements in 10y UST futures on 15 Oct 2014;
red=better liquidity, blue=worse



Source: Nanex representation of TY data (CBOT)

...making for unprecedented price moves

Histogram of Blue Eurodollar futures daily moves expressed in standard deviations of 3m range, 2006-14



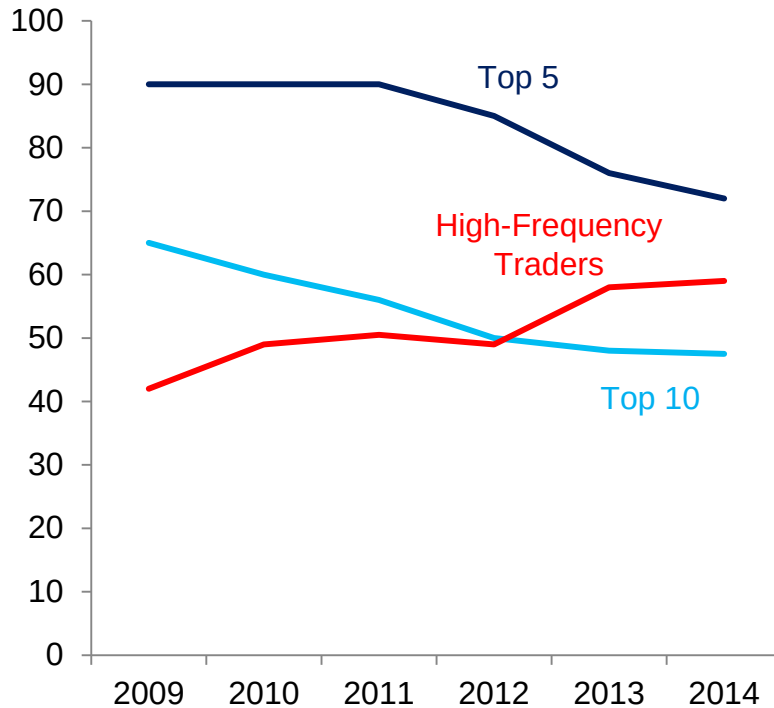
Source: CME, Citi Research.

Unusual – but hardly a once per 3 billion year event

Were there any warning signs?

Increased HFT participation, perhaps

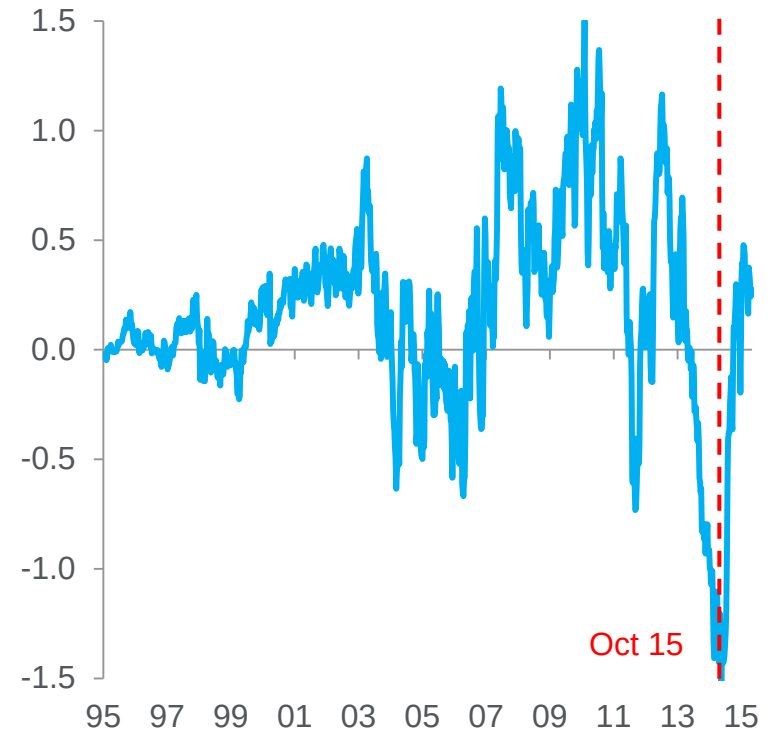
Proportion of inter-dealer trading by counterparty in USTs, %



Source: Brokertec.

Positioning was also extreme

Net speculative positioning in Eurodollars, million contracts



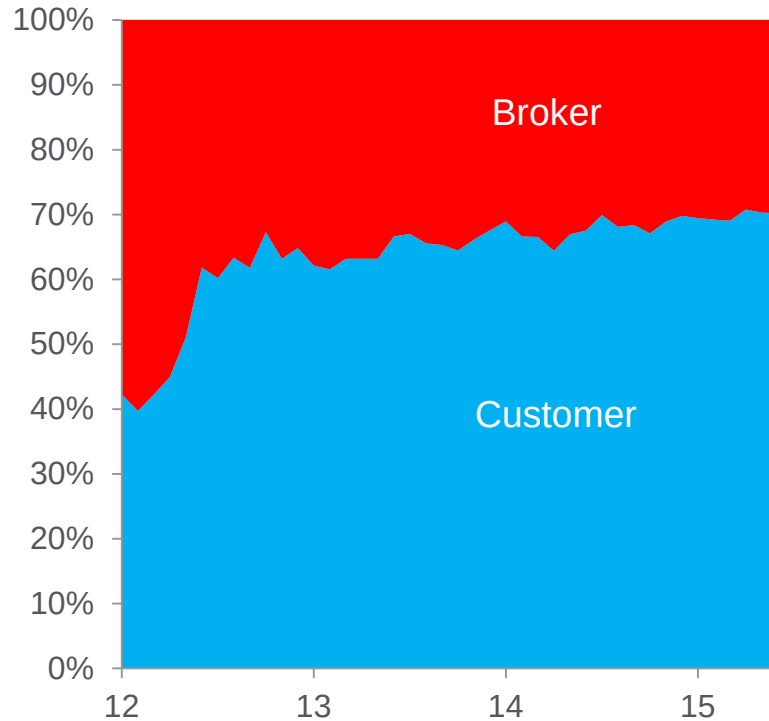
Source: CFTC.

Dealers and HFTs suddenly pulled away

But IDB trades are only a fraction of the market

Investors choose dealers over brokers...

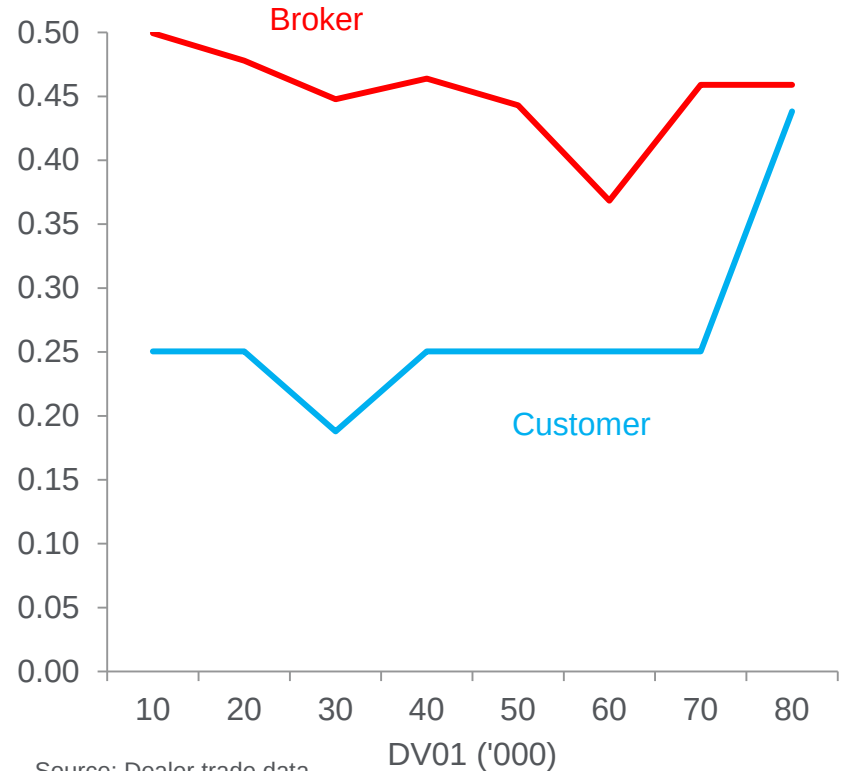
Sample dealer, UST trading by counterparty



Source: Dealer trade data.

...in part because of better bid-offer

Execution cost by trade size and counterparty, UST OTR 7-30y, distance from mid (ticks)



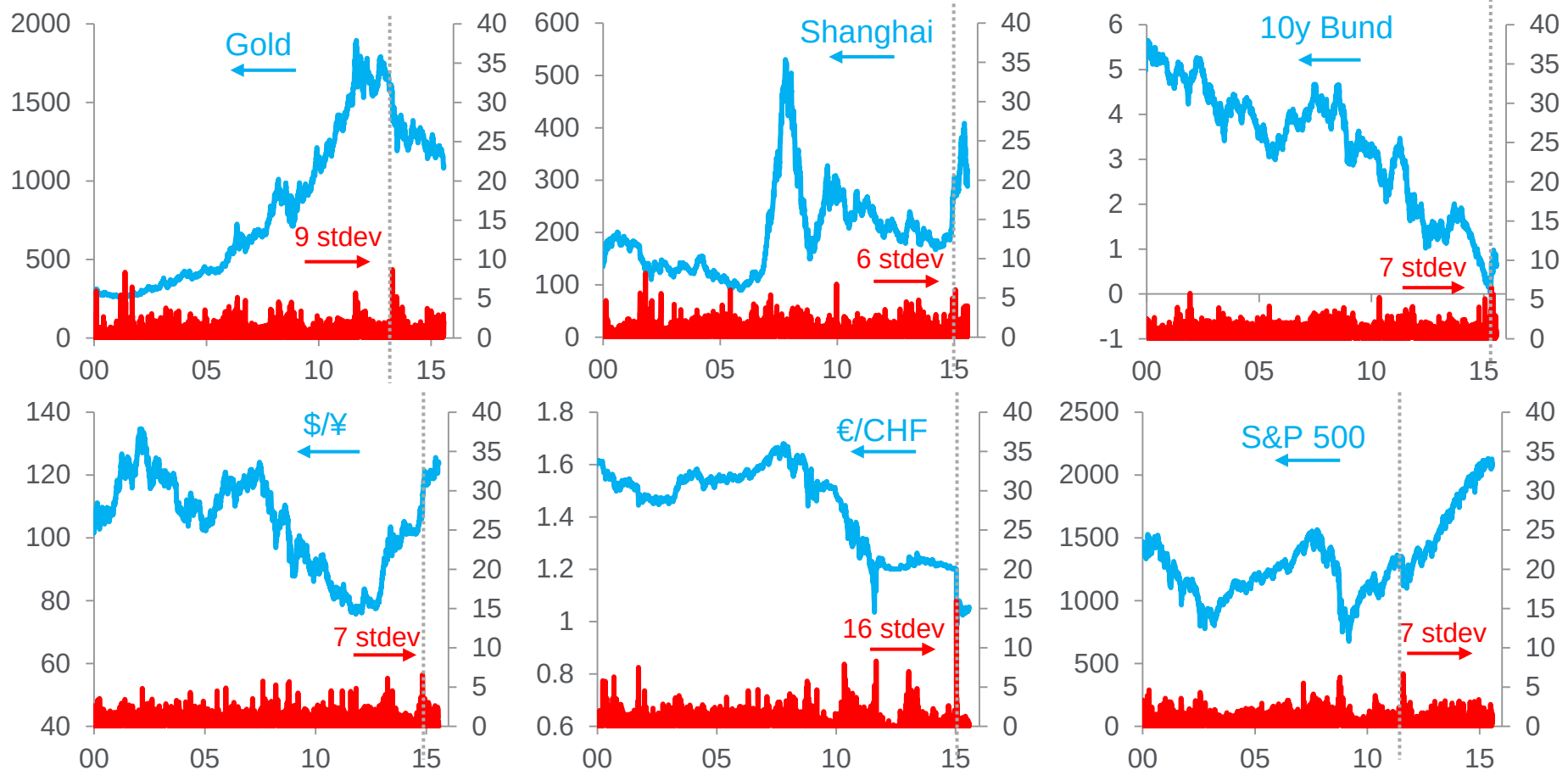
Source: Dealer trade data.

Focus on inter-dealer trades
exaggerates the importance of HFT

Other markets are suffering bouts of illiquidity too

Just a widespread case of the hiccups?

Daily absolute price moves expressed as multiple of 1y standard deviation



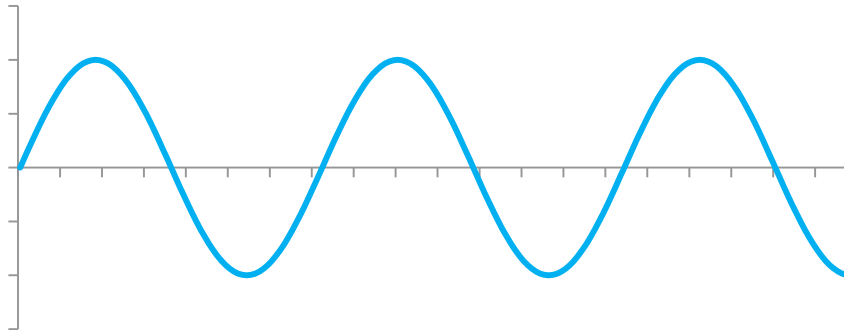
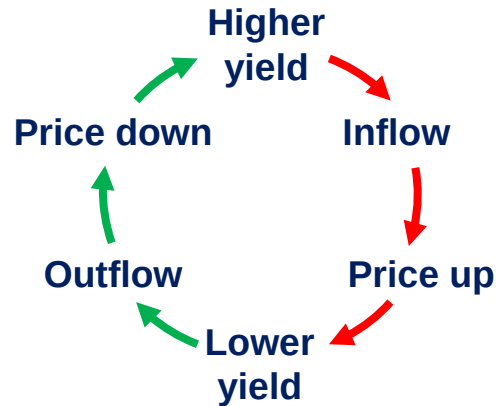
Source: Haver Analytics.

This can't just be about dealer balance sheet

Have market dynamics changed?

Normally, price movements are self-limiting

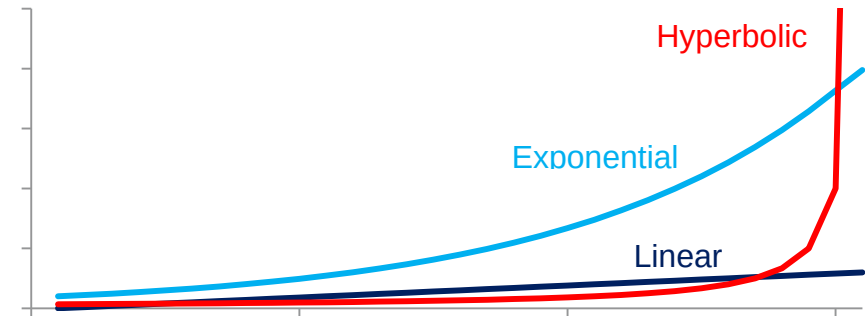
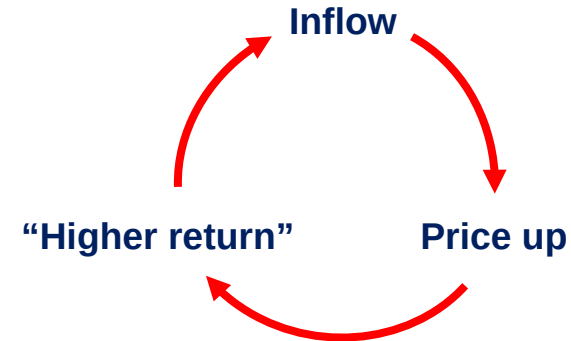
Negative feedback loop



Source: Citi Research.

Today's moves feel different

Positive feedback loop



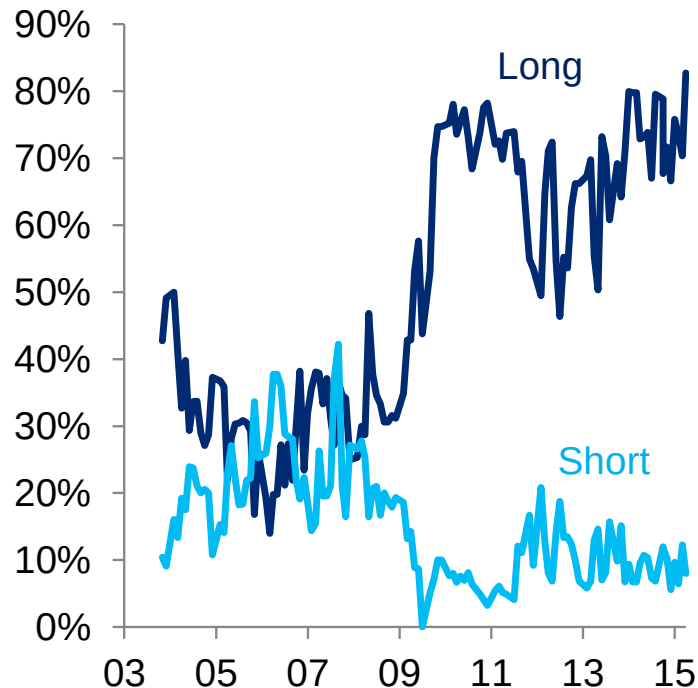
Source: Citi Research.

Investors buying not on value but on inflows

Evidence of herding

One-way market

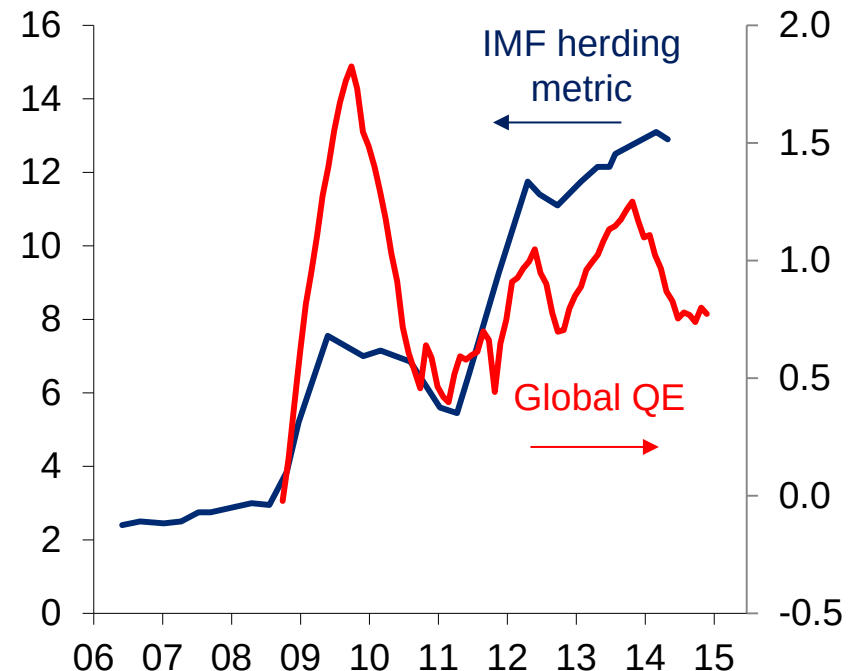
Dealer credit survey positioning, % of respondents



Source: Citi Research.

More QE, more crowded positioning

Herding index* vs global central bank purchases, rolling 6m, \$tn



Source: IMF, Citi Research.

* Derived from correlation between security-by-security transactions in US mutual funds across a variety of asset classes.

Extreme monetary policy has caused herding -
removing it will be difficult

Assessing fixed-income liquidity

Regulation and structural change

Liquidity in financial shocks

Best practices and innovation

What should be done?

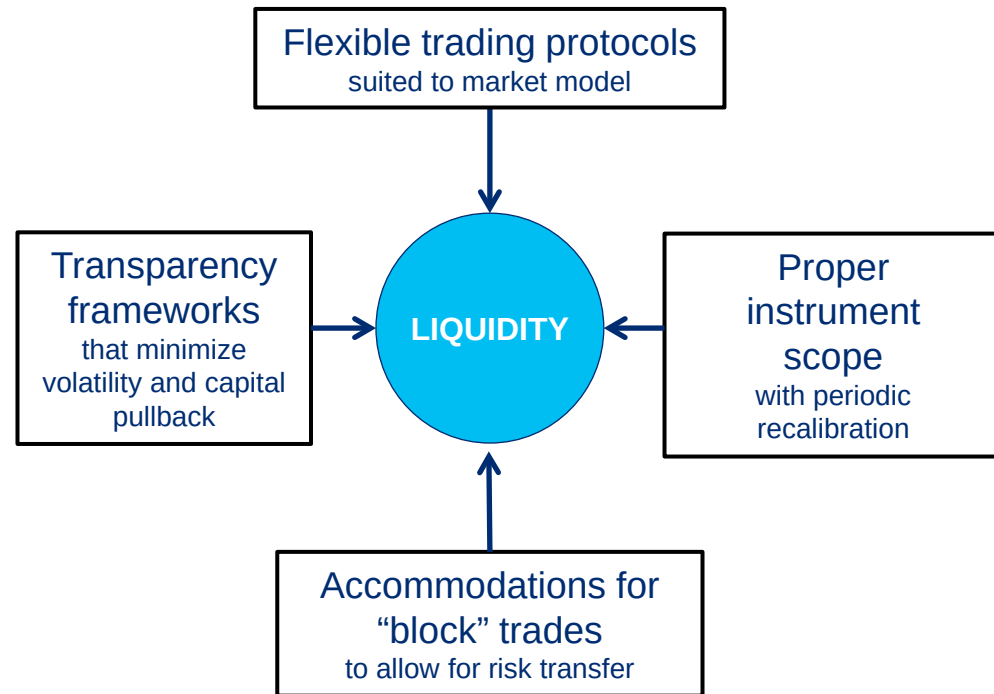
Action and reaction

Potential measures and complications

End user repo clearing	• Risk sharing problematic
Regulate end users	• Hard to enforce 'skin in the game'
Regulate venues	• Sensible, but will not eliminate vol
Encourage all-to-all trading	• Works only when 2-way interest exists
Greater transparency and standardization	• Requires careful calibration by market

Balance evolution with revolution

Use a phased approach, and consider multiple dimensions



Multiple measures possible –
none of which will eliminate the problem entirely

Protocols should accommodate market and allow evolution



Think less of enforcing participation, and more about removing barriers to confidence

Building safe electronic markets



SEC Chair, Mary Jo White

Commentary to the major equities markets following the 08/01/12 Knight Capital Market-Making software glitch and the 08/22/12 NASDAQ trade halt

The relevant parties in consultation with other market participants will:

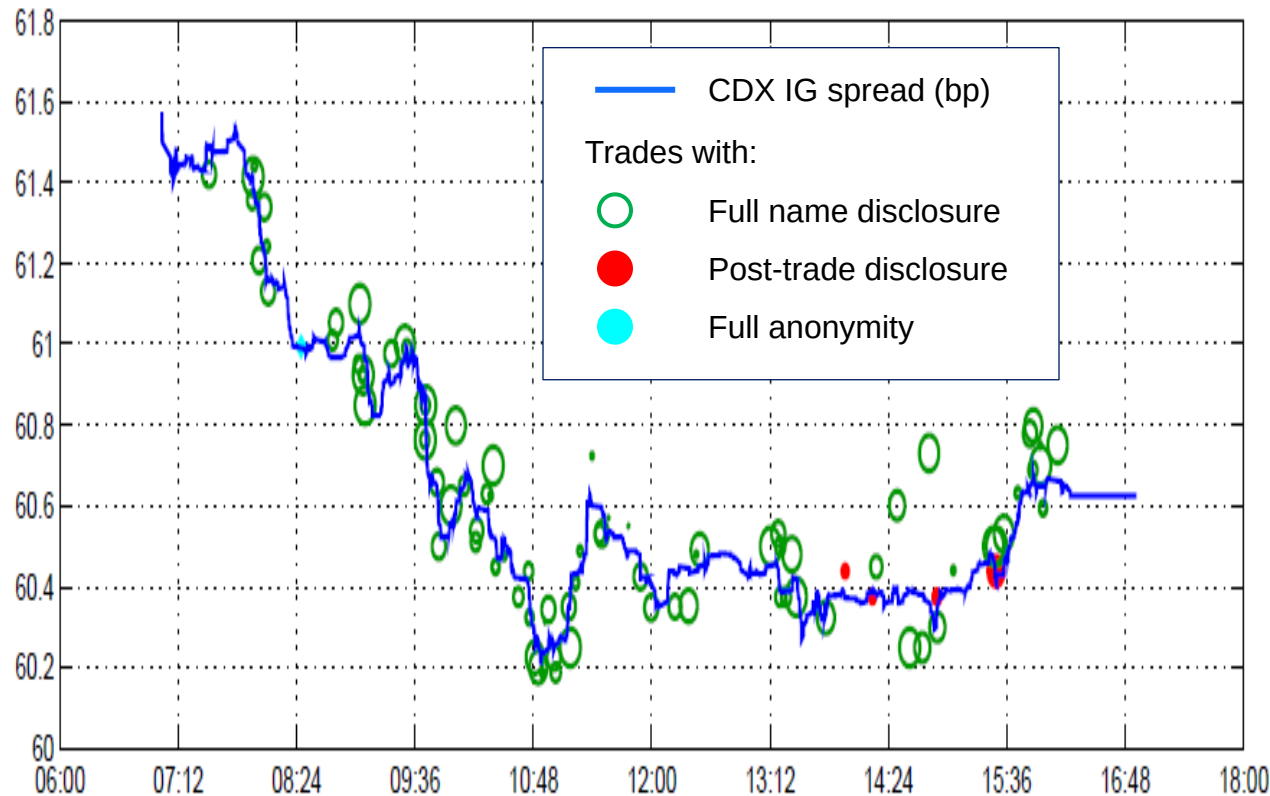
- Provide comprehensive action plans that address the standards necessary to establish highly resilient and robust systems for the securities information processors (SIPs), including testing standards and disclosure protocols.
- Identify and provide assessments of the robustness and resilience of other critical infrastructure systems.
- Provide SIP plan and/or rule amendments addressing the issuance, effectiveness, and communication of regulatory halts.
- Review their rules relating to the trade break process and procedures to reopen trading following a trading halt, and provide amendments to those rules as necessary.
- Provide rule amendments to implement “kill switches” that would allow exchanges to shut down trading in the event of technological failures, and review and consider other potential risk mitigation mechanisms.

Best practices from more evolved
electronic markets still missing in FI

Post-trade anonymity

Anonymity proves unpopular

CDX IG SEF trade analysis by trading venue and trade size (diameter), 15 Apr 2015



Source: Bloomberg SDR.

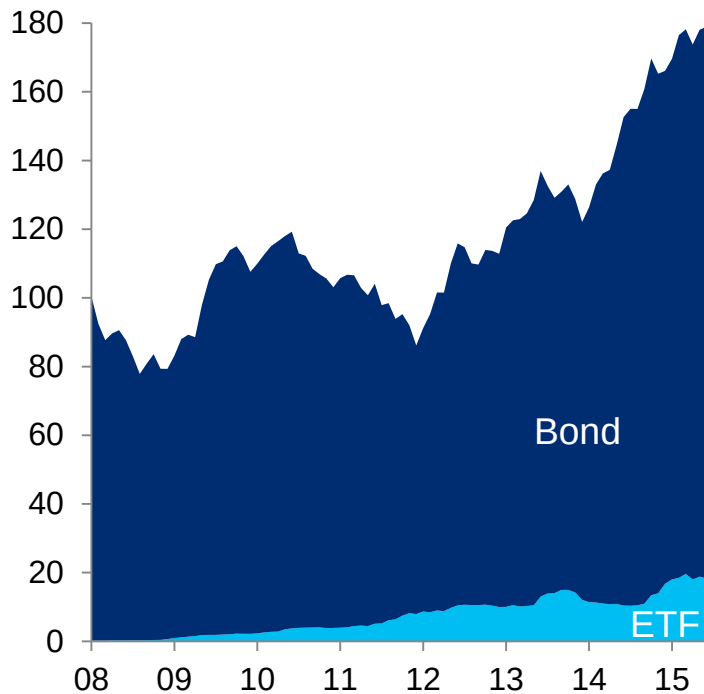
- More trades and larger sizes executed via fully name disclosed RFQ protocol
- Liquidity seekers currently prefer bilateral dealer-client platforms because of greater liquidity and higher execution certainty

Liquidity best on platforms with name give-up

ETFs

Adding to liquidity, not reducing it

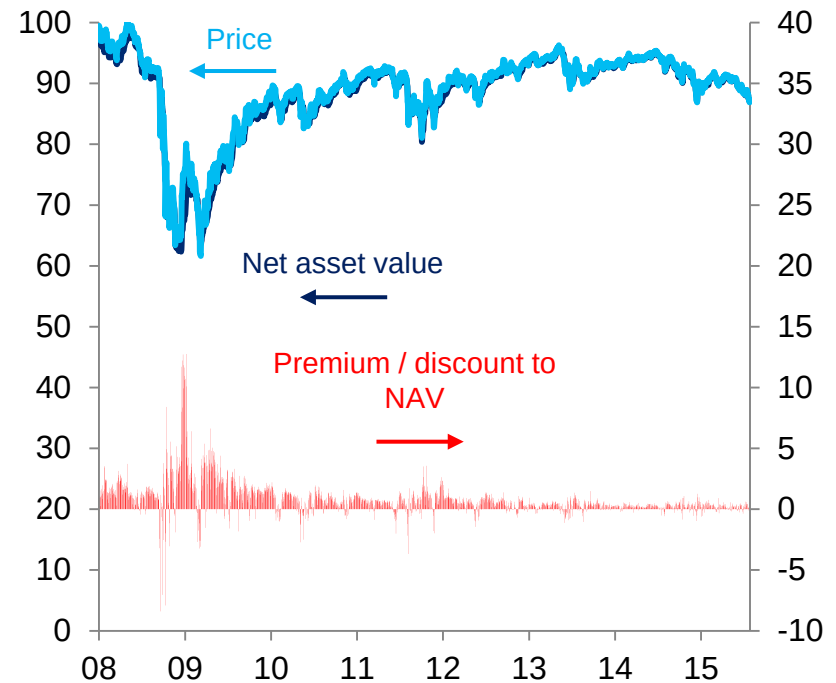
HY cash trading by instrument, 6m avg, \$bn



Source: Bloomberg.

A built-in buffer for shocks

HY ETF price and net asset value comparison



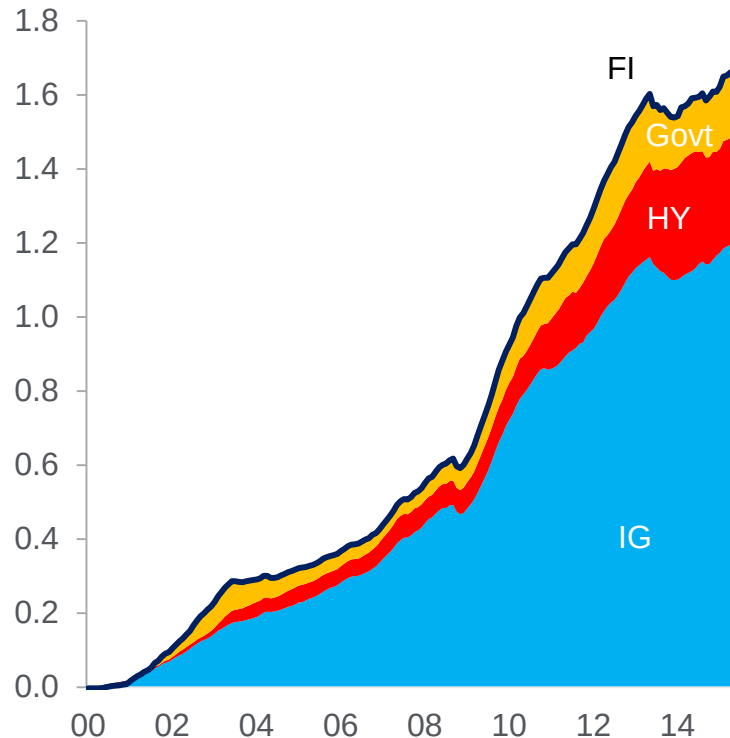
Source: Bloomberg.

Ability to trade at discount to NAV means buffer built in

Mutual fund stress tests and liquidity buffers

The industry's growth may be steady

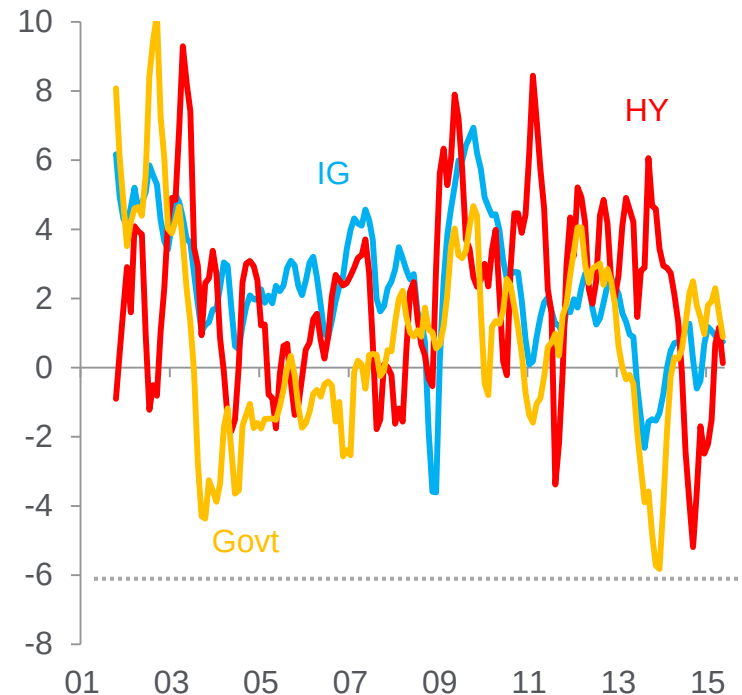
Cumulative net sales since 2000, mutual fund + ETF, \$tn



Source: ICI.

But individual fund flows vary substantially

Net quarterly sales by asset class, % AUM, mutual fund + ETF



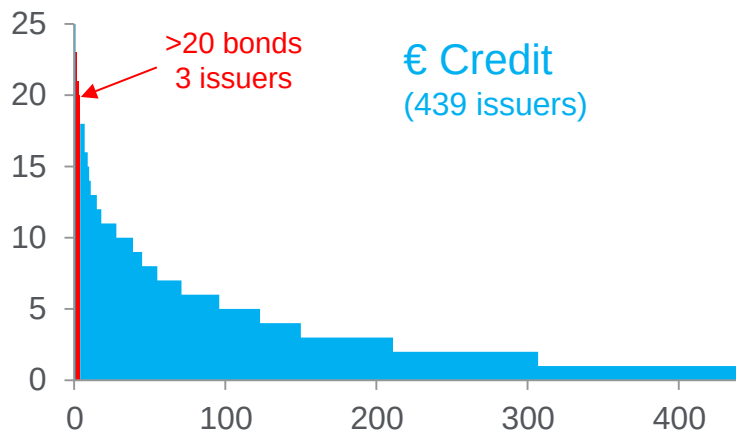
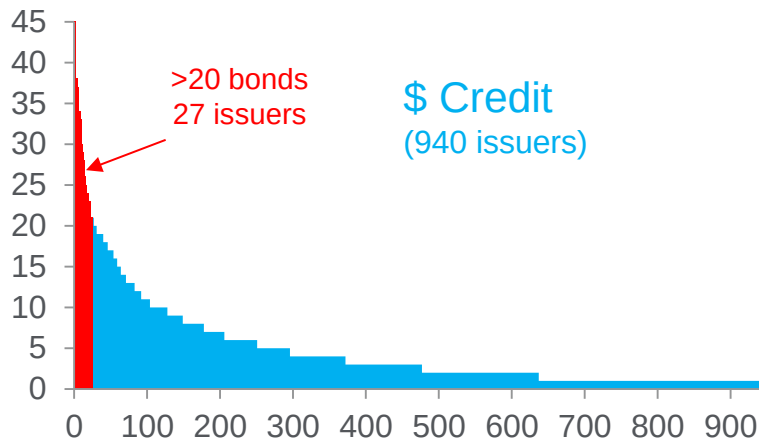
Source: ICI.

Encourage safeguards against firesales,
whether self-imposed or regulated

Standardizing corporate issuance

Most issuers have only a few bonds...

Number of bonds outstanding by issuer, \$ and € IG



Source: Markit.

...and cherish their flexibility

Considerations upon issuance consolidation

Maturity Management

- Large Towers can cause significant refinancing and credit risk

Reopening Bond amid Fluctuating Rates and Credit Markets

- Potential OID and Premium issues

Bespoke Transactions for Each Issuer

- Potential impediment on capital raising strategies

Standardized Coupons

- Hinder cash management strategies

Covenant Language

- Could be used by issuers, limiting bond reopening

Infrequent, Small issuers

- Elevated borrowing costs as a result of not reaching the threshold

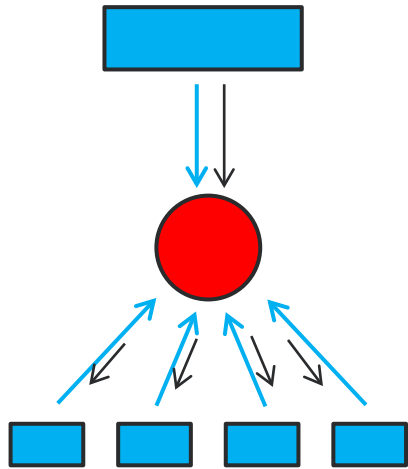
Secondary Market Underperformance

- Reopening of bonds could push issuers wider

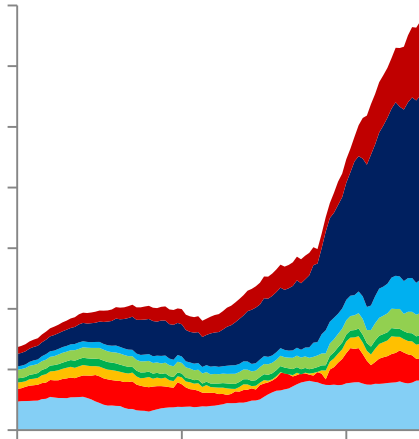
Would help only a small number of borrowers

Conclusion

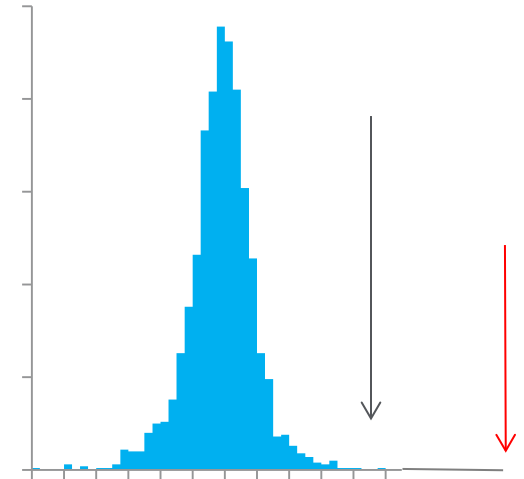
A shift towards an agent-based model



...and a loss of heterogeneity...



...leaves liquidity vulnerable to the whims of end users



Expect more bouts of illiquidity ahead

Appendix A-1

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